

## CHAPTER 1 • ORIENTATION

## 01

← you are here

So what the hell  
is Claude Code

what you're signing up for



Difficulty

Easy

Time

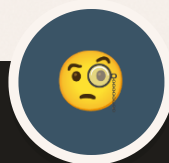
5-10 min

Value

Yes

## You'll know

- ✓ What it actually is
- ✓ What it isn't (and why)
- ✓ Why anyone bothers



## Hard questions

- 1 Will it replace me?
- 2 Is my data safe?
- 3 What if it makes stuff up?
- 4 Am I going to burn out?

## CONCEPT · SECTION 1 OF 9

# What it actually is.

*(short version: you type, claude does things.)*

Claude Code is a thing you type into your computer's terminal. You talk to it. It can **read** your files, **write** new ones, **run** commands, and remember things between sessions.

It's not a website. It's not a copilot in your sidebar. It runs in a terminal window. The same place a developer would run code.

Underneath, it's **Claude** (the AI made by Anthropic) wired up to your computer in a useful way.

## I PLAIN ENGLISH

A "terminal" is a text window. You type a sentence, the computer does something. Press **Enter** to send.

## PLAIN ENGLISH

**terminal**: the text window. Also called "console" or "command line." Same thing.

## PLAIN ENGLISH

**Anthropic**: the company that makes Claude.

## ALSO HELPFUL

What it's *not*: **section 3**

Why bother: **section 4**

## RABBIT HOLE

*The word "shell" comes from the fact it wraps the kernel. You will never need to care about this.*

TANGENT ↗ SKIPPABLE (it's fine to skip this, meet you on the next page)

## About where this book actually lives.



The PDF in your hands is a **snapshot**. The real version of this book lives on the internet, in what engineers call a "repo." If you've heard "git repo" thrown around and felt left out, congrats, it's a folder. Engineers have a special word for folder. That's the whole mystery.

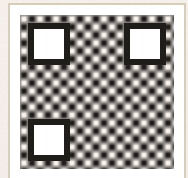
By the time you're reading this, the online version has probably gotten newer.



### READ THE LATEST

[github.com/brandonrhecker/honestly-claude-code](https://github.com/brandonrhecker/honestly-claude-code)

No account. No software. Pretend it's just a webpage. It is.



scan: repo

### NO PANIC

*you don't need git  
to read the book.*



## CONCEPT · SECTION 3 OF 9

# What it's not.

*Four things, mostly*

It helps to name what this isn't before naming what it is. Otherwise you'll keep importing baggage from the last AI thing you saw.

**Not a chatbot.**

A chatbot just talks. This does things. Edits files, runs commands, looks at git.

**Not autonomous.**

It asks permission before doing anything destructive. You're the human in the loop.

**Not for engineers only.**

You don't need to know how to code. You do need to be willing to type into a terminal. There's a difference.

**Not magic.**

It will get things wrong. Sometimes spectacularly. We'll cover how to catch it.

**TAKEAWAY**

*if it scares you,  
good. that's  
useful skepticism.*



## CONCEPT · SECTION 4 OF 9

# Why anyone bothers.

*(it's not about the hype.)*

You can hand off the tedious stuff. The "I have this file, can you rename it and update the references" stuff. The "organize my downloads folder by date" stuff. The "write me a checklist for the trip I'm planning" stuff.

It's not going to replace you. It's going to handle the work that's **beneath** you so you can do the work that **isn't**.

## THE ONE-LINER

*Boring work, gone. Real work, still yours.*



### FOR EXAMPLE

Rename 200 photos by date. **ch. 03**



### FOR EXAMPLE

Draft a checklist from a half-baked idea. **ch. 04**



### FOR EXAMPLE

Organize a folder you've been avoiding. **ch. 03**



### BUT WAIT

The next 4 sections are the honest ones. Read them.

— BUT WAIT · SECTION 5 OF 9

# Am I going to lose my job?

Honest answer: maybe parts of it, probably not the whole thing.

The people who lean hardest into AI tools tend to climb faster, not get replaced. The people who refuse to touch it tend to get left behind. Neither's a great option.

What works best: learn enough to know what it's **good at** and what it **isn't**, then use it where it actually helps. Ignore the hype where it doesn't.

## TL;DR

Refusing to engage is its own risk. So is going all-in. The middle path is boring and it works.

MORE IN CHAPTER 09

*Will it replace me?* The long version.



— BUT WAIT · SECTION 6 OF 9

## Is my data safe?

Short version: your **conversations** go to Anthropic's servers to get processed. **Files** Claude reads stay on your computer unless you explicitly ask it to share them somewhere.

By default it **can't access the internet**. That's important. If you don't give it the wifi keys, it can't phone home with your stuff.

### TL;DR

Conversations leave. Files stay. The thing has to ask you before it goes online.

MORE IN CHAPTER 09

*Is my data safe?* The long version.





— BUT WAIT · SECTION 7 OF 9

## What if it just makes shit up?

It does, sometimes. **Confidently. With zero hedging.** That's the most important thing about it to remember.

The fix isn't to never use it. The fix is to never **trust it blindly**. Especially on facts, names, dates, code, or anything that matters.

You're the human. You're the check.

### TL;DR

Yes, it lies. Confidently. Your job is to check. That part hasn't changed.

MORE IN CHAPTER 09

*When it screws up. The long version.*



— THE HONEST PART · SECTION 8 OF 9

## About burnout.

Using AI is going to take mental energy you weren't spending before. Some days it'll save you hours. Some days it'll waste an hour and you'll feel dumb. That's normal.

If you start to feel burned out, **stop**. Use it less. Letting a tool run you is the same trap as the old job, just with a new tool.

### TL;DR

It will save you time some days and cost you time others. If it starts owning you, walk away for a while.

MORE IN CHAPTER 09

*Burning out in an automated world. The long version.*



## CHAPTER 1 · RECAP

*tl;dr*

tear this page out if you want

# The whole chapter, on one page.

**1 It runs in your terminal.**

Not a website, not a sidebar. A text window you type at.

**2 It does, not just talks.**

Reads your files, writes new ones, runs commands. With permission.

**3 It's not magic, it's not your replacement.**

It'll get things wrong. You're the human, you're the check.

**4 It can save you real time on real tasks.**

Boring work gone. Real work still yours.

**5 Your fears are legitimate.**

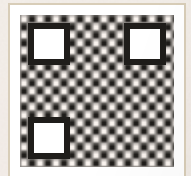
We'll cover them honestly in ch. 9.

**6 Burned out? Stop.**

Don't let a tool run you. That's the old trap.

**★ ONE THING TO REMEMBER**

*The fears are real. The answers are nuanced. Both can be true.*



scan: ch.01



## UP NEXT • CHAPTER 2

## 02

*Get the damn thing running.*

Install Claude Code on your machine. We do Mac, Windows, and Linux. Pick one, skip the rest.



STARTS NEXT



## YOU WILL DO

Install Claude on your actual machine.

## YOU WILL SEE

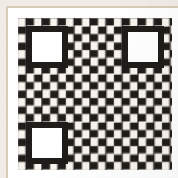
Claude say hello back in plain English.

## DIFFICULTY

Still easy. Promise.

*see you on the next page*

honestly, **brandon**. still not an algorithm



repo • ch.02